

Hope



An anchor on the seafloor, chain rising into the light. The holding place is not the sailor's mood. The flukes are in something solid, out of sight.

OPEN PART V BY SAYING

Hope, glory, and God's choice before the world began. We teach election last so the room hears it as comfort, not as a puzzle. God chose a people in Christ. Whoever comes to Jesus, He will never cast out.

Before you gather

- Read Day 28, Hope, in **The Visual Gospel**. Do not reteach the devotional.
- Read Hebrews 6:17–20 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 • ICEBREAKER • 7 MIN

Open the room

Name something you are confident will happen, not something you merely wish would happen.

Leader. Confidence versus a wish. The book already asked how trials show where hope lies, and it used Ephesians 1. Do not reopen those. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 • THE WORD • 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Biblical hope is not "I hope so." It is a confident expectation. The anchor goes behind the curtain, into God's presence, because Jesus the risen Christ has already gone in. The chain holds when your mood does not.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Hope is the confident expectation of future good, grounded in the promises of God and secured by the finished work of Jesus Christ.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek *elpis* — confident expectation, not a wish.

MEMORY VERSE • HEBREWS 6:19

We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul, a hope that enters into the inner place behind the curtain.

Read day 28 of **The Visual Gospel** before you teach it. The drawing and the personal questions are there.

Together, open the flashcard for Hope. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Hebrews 6:17–20

Read the memory verse inside its paragraph. The anchor is God's oath and Jesus our forerunner, not a technique for sad people. Hope is tied to a promise God cannot break.

So when God desired to show more convincingly to the heirs of the promise the unchangeable character of his purpose, he guaranteed it with an oath, so that by two unchangeable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie, we who have fled for refuge might have strong encouragement to hold fast to the hope set before us. We have this as a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul, a hope that enters into the inner place behind the curtain, where Jesus has gone as a forerunner on our behalf.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. What two unchangeable things make this hope strong, and where does the anchor actually go? **CORE**

Leader. God's promise and God's oath. It is impossible for God to lie. The anchor enters behind the curtain, where Jesus has gone as a forerunner. Hope is fastened to the risen Christ in God's presence, not to a feeling.

2. Verse 18: who is this strong encouragement for, and what had they done?

Leader. Heirs of the promise who have fled for refuge. Hope belongs to people who needed somewhere to run, not to people who have life under control.

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Read Romans 8:23–25. Paul says we hope for what we do not see, and we wait for it with patience. How is that different from pretending this week is fine? **CORE**

Leader. Christian hope tells the truth about groaning and still expects the redemption of our bodies. It is not denial. It is not a wish. It is confidence in what God has promised.

4. 1 Peter 1:3–4 ties a living hope to the resurrection of Jesus Christ and to an inheritance that does not fade, kept in heaven. What are you hoping in that can spoil or be taken, and what cannot?

Leader. Health, money, a political result, a child's success, even a ministry. Name them without shaming. Those are not the anchor. The risen Christ, and the inheritance God keeps, cannot be taken.

5. The flukes of the anchor are out of sight. What does it look like, this week, to hold fast to a hope you cannot see?

Leader. Pray God's promise back to Him. Stay with the saints. Open the Word again. Refuse a smaller god. Not a smile you put on for the group. We follow the Spirit by the Word, not by how hopeful we feel.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Hope is a confident expectation of future good, grounded in God's promise and in the risen Christ, not a wish.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Sit with someone who is afraid of what is coming, and carry one concrete load for them. Tell them hope in Christ is not a wish. It is confidence in the risen Jesus and in promises God keeps.

Leader. Do not correct their grief. Carry something. Then speak. The sentence names the risen Christ. It is not “things will work out.” Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank God that He cannot lie, and that Jesus has already gone in ahead of His people.
2. Name one groan you will not pretend is fine, and set it beside His promise.
3. Ask for a hope strong enough to wait, without grabbing a smaller anchor.

Before you stumble

Part V begins: the story is going somewhere. Do not explain someone’s suffering as a lesson they should have learned faster. Hebrews was written to people in danger of drifting, not to people who needed a scolding. If someone is in real despair, the anchor is Jesus the forerunner, not their ability to feel hopeful before they leave. Stay after if you need to. Do not prescribe silence as the cure. Put a promise in their hands.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what they mean when they say “hopefully.” Then ask what Hebrews requires before that word is Christian hope. The bar is God’s oath and the risen Christ, not their optimism.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Romans 15:13, if the night was heavy. The God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing, by the power of the Holy Spirit. And 1 Peter 3:15: be ready to give a reason for the hope that is in you. The reason is Christ, not a mood.